

MILESTONES**BECOMES FELLOW**

Accepts a fellowship at the Ontario Cancer Institute in 1972, following the completion of his doctorate.

T-CELL FINDINGS

Details the genetic encoding of human T-cell receptors in *Nature* journal's March 1984 edition.

GENETIC RESEARCH

Uses experiments with mice to isolate genetic function for cancer and immunology studies in 1988.

TARGETED TREATMENT

Identifies a chemical to block the fuel supply of Hodgkin's lymphoma, a rare form of cancer, in 1999.

Immunologist and molecular biologist Tak Wah Mak discovered how T-cells, which are part of the body's immune system, recognize antigens and advanced our molecular knowledge of cancer cells.

Tak Wah Mak was born in southern China in 1946, the son of a wealthy silk trader, and spent his childhood in Hong Kong. With his family, he then moved to the US, where he studied at the University of Wisconsin. He gained a PhD in biochemistry at the University of Alberta, Canada, in 1968.

Mak's research on T-cells, a type of white blood cell produced by the thymus gland, led to him solving a longstanding problem in immunology—how receptors on the surface of T-cells recognized antigens (substances that provoke the body's immune response). His breakthrough came in 1983 with the discovery that the genes of T-cell receptors used for antigen recognition have a unique genetic sequence and origin. This discovery opened up a new chapter in the study and treatment of immune-system diseases. Mak then applied molecular techniques to learn more about immune responses to cancer.

“We can never give up the fight against [cancer].”

Tak Wah Mak, 2011

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